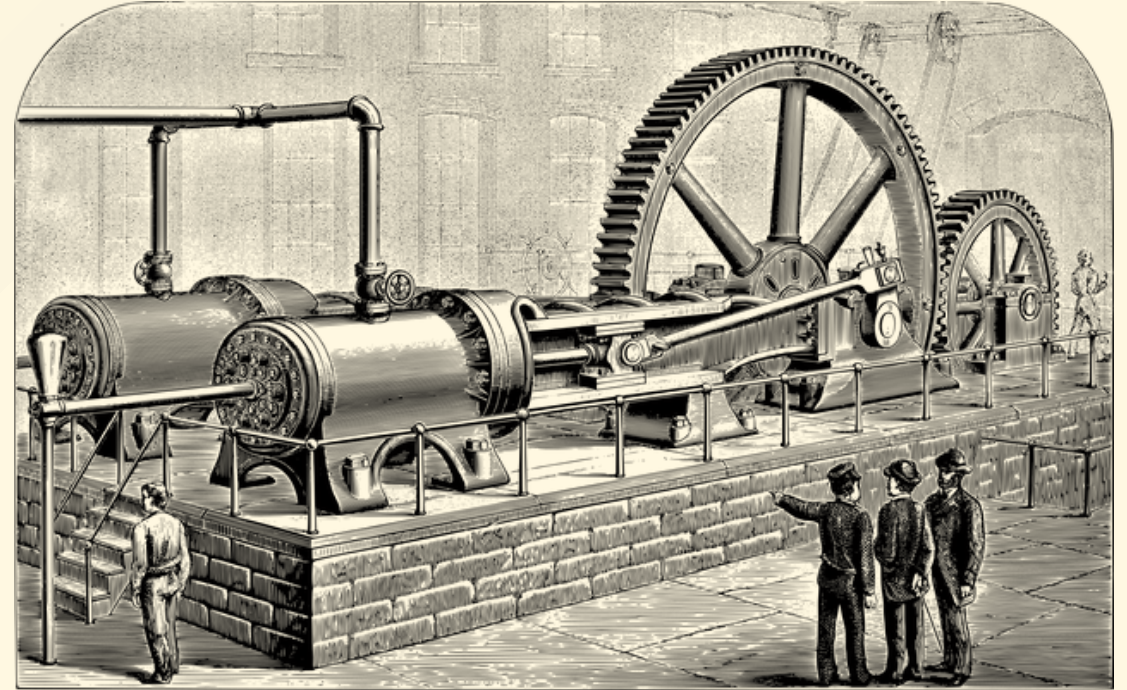


ECO 331

Economic History

Introduction

Jonathan Conning
Spring 2026



Required Texts

- Koyama, Mark, Rubin, Jared, 2022. *How the World Became Rich: The Historical Origins of Economic Growth*. John Wiley & Sons.
- Galor, Oded, 2022. *The Journey of Humanity: The Origins of Wealth and Inequality*. Penguin.

Reasonably priced in e-book, print, and/or audio formats.

Canvas LMS

canvas.instructure.com/enroll/P9XDGD

- Syllabus, Reading Schedule
- Threaded Discussions
- Homework and grades
- free

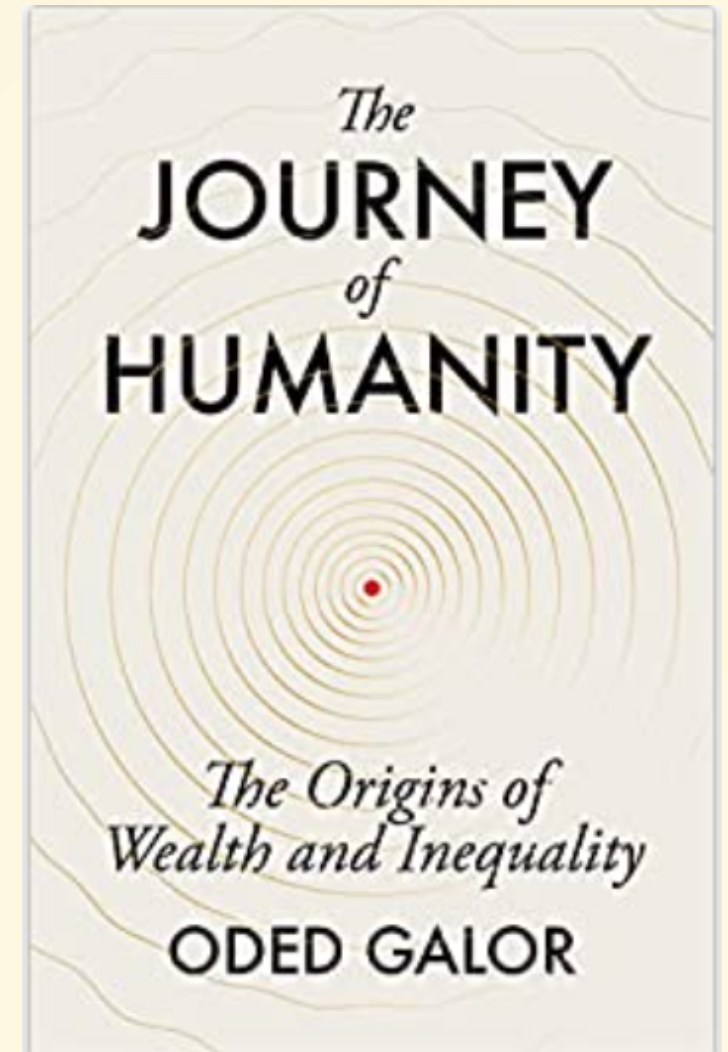
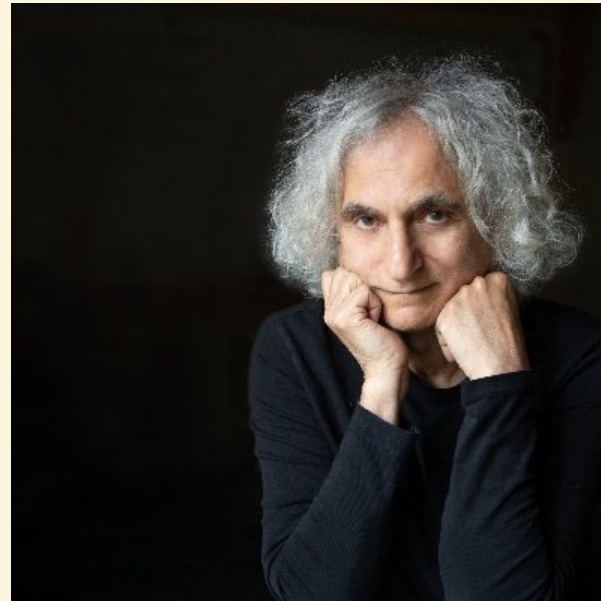


Grading



Activity	pct
Discussion/Participation	35 %
Midterm	20 %
Article/Chapter Report	15 %
Final Exam	30 %

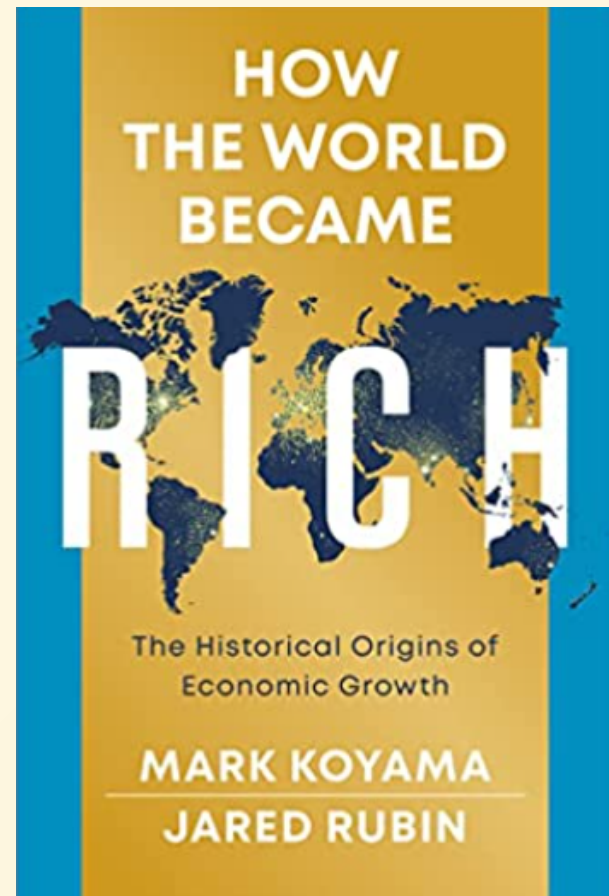
Oded Galor
Brown University



Unified Growth Theory

Oded Galor





Mark Koyama
(GWU)

Jared Rubin
(Chapman
Univ)

'Big History' Questions

- How did the world become Rich?
- Why did it take so long?
- Why did it happen first in some places before others?
- Why isn't the whole world rich?

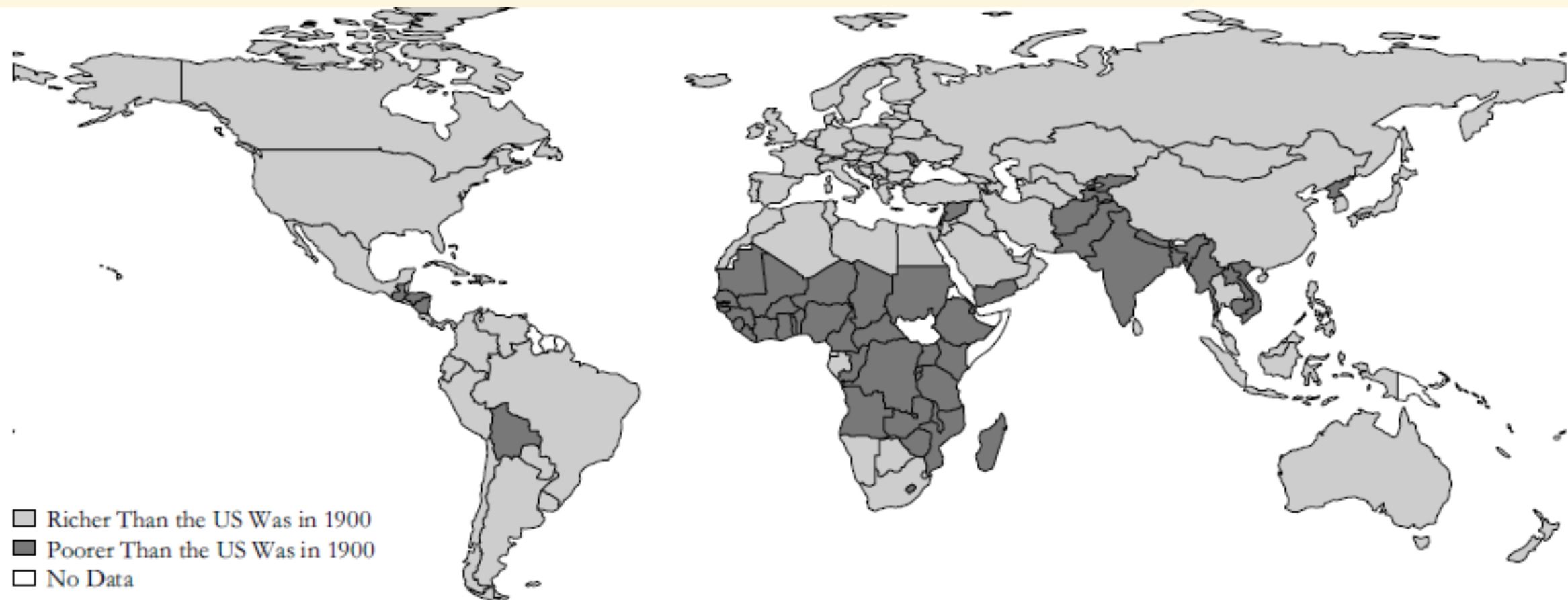


Figure 1.1 Countries that were richer in 2018 (annual per capita income) than the US in 1900
Data source: Bolt and van Zanden (2020). Average income in the US in 1900 was \$8,970 in 2011 USD.

Transitions

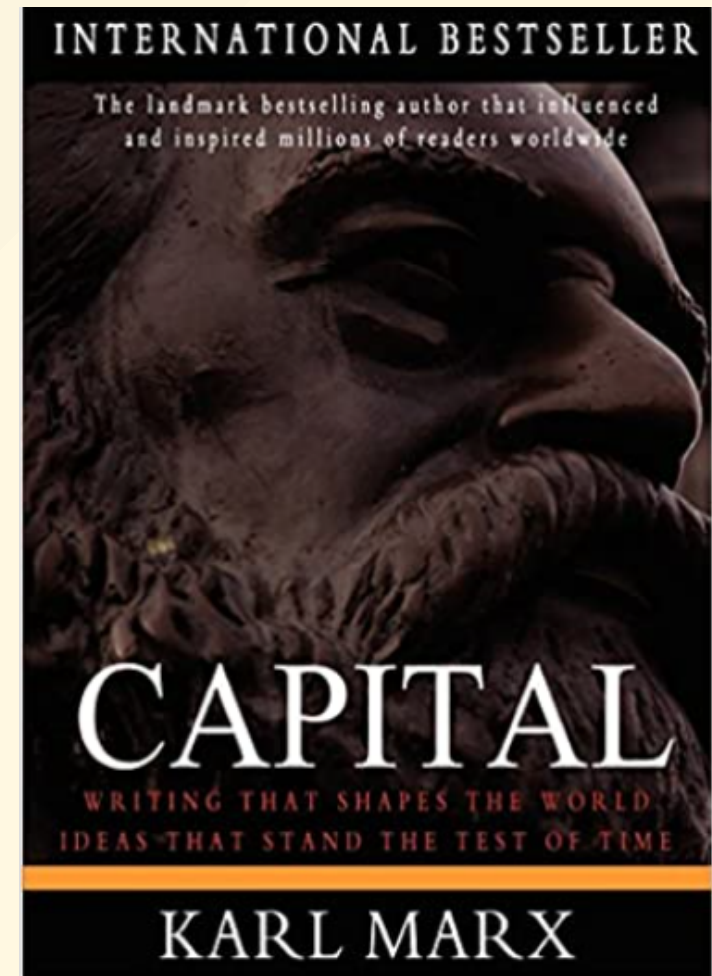
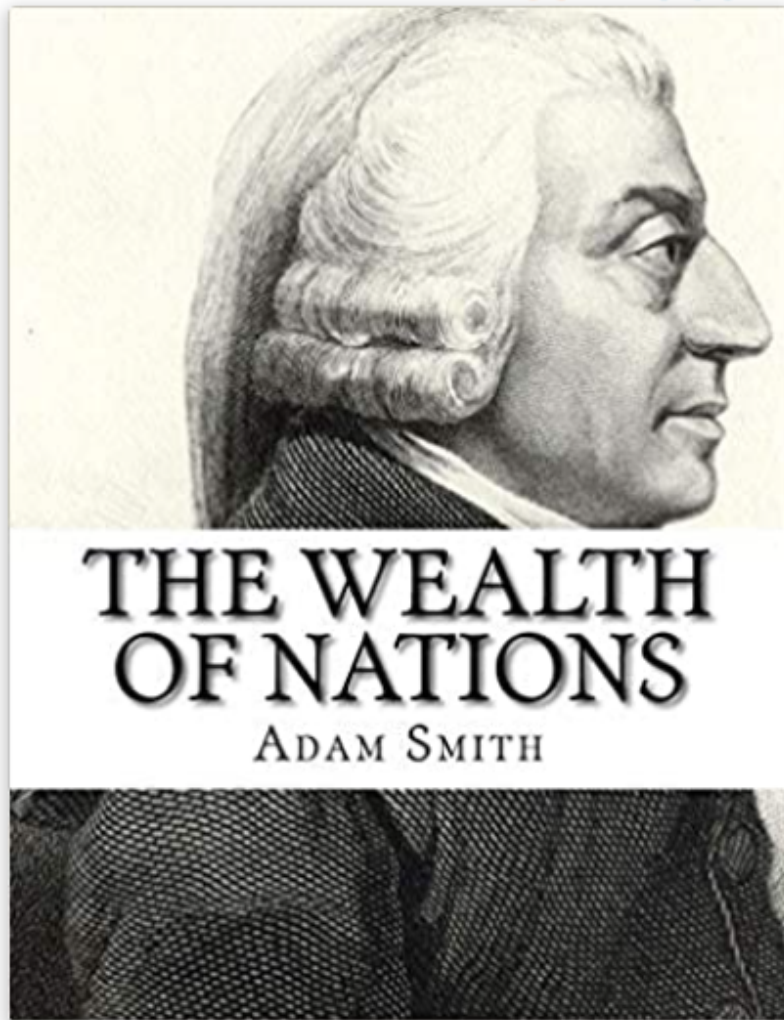
- The Neolithic Revolution
- Early States, Empires
- Malthusian Trap
- Rise and Fall of Feudalism

Transitions (continued)

- Capitalist Transitions
 - The enclosure of lands
 - The rise of cities, Modern States
 - Demographic Transitions. Malthusian escape
- Conquest, Colonization, Slavery
- The Industrial Revolution(s)
 - Firms, Technology R&D
 - Global Trade and Finance



Classical Political Economy



Barrington Moore, Jr.

SOCIAL ORIGINS OF DICTATORSHIP AND DEMOCRACY

With a new Foreword by Edward Friedman and James C. Scott

LORD AND PEASANT
IN THE MAKING OF
THE MODERN WORLD

"A profoundly important book."

- New York Times Book Review

WINNER OF THE PULITZER PRIZE

A MAJOR
PBS
SPECIAL

GUNS, GERMS, AND STEEL

The FATES of HUMAN SOCIETIES

JARED DIAMOND

WITH A NEW AFTERWORD

THE GREAT

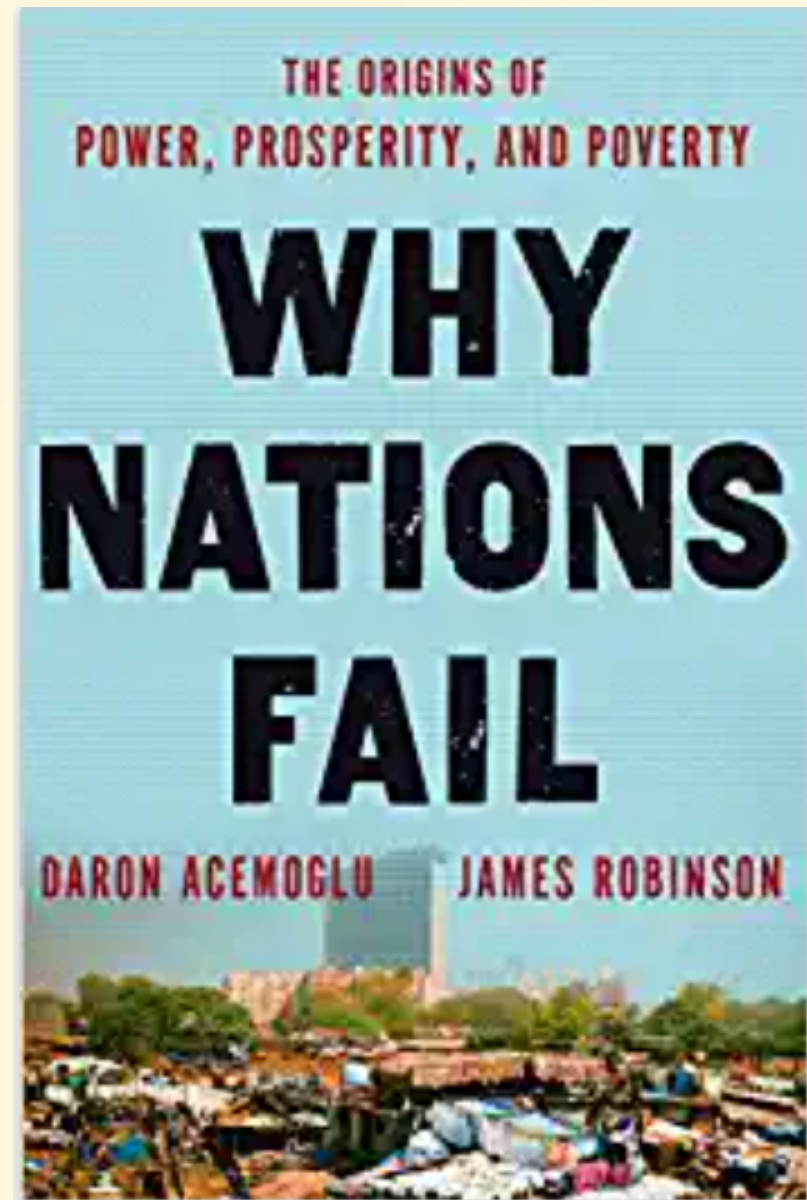
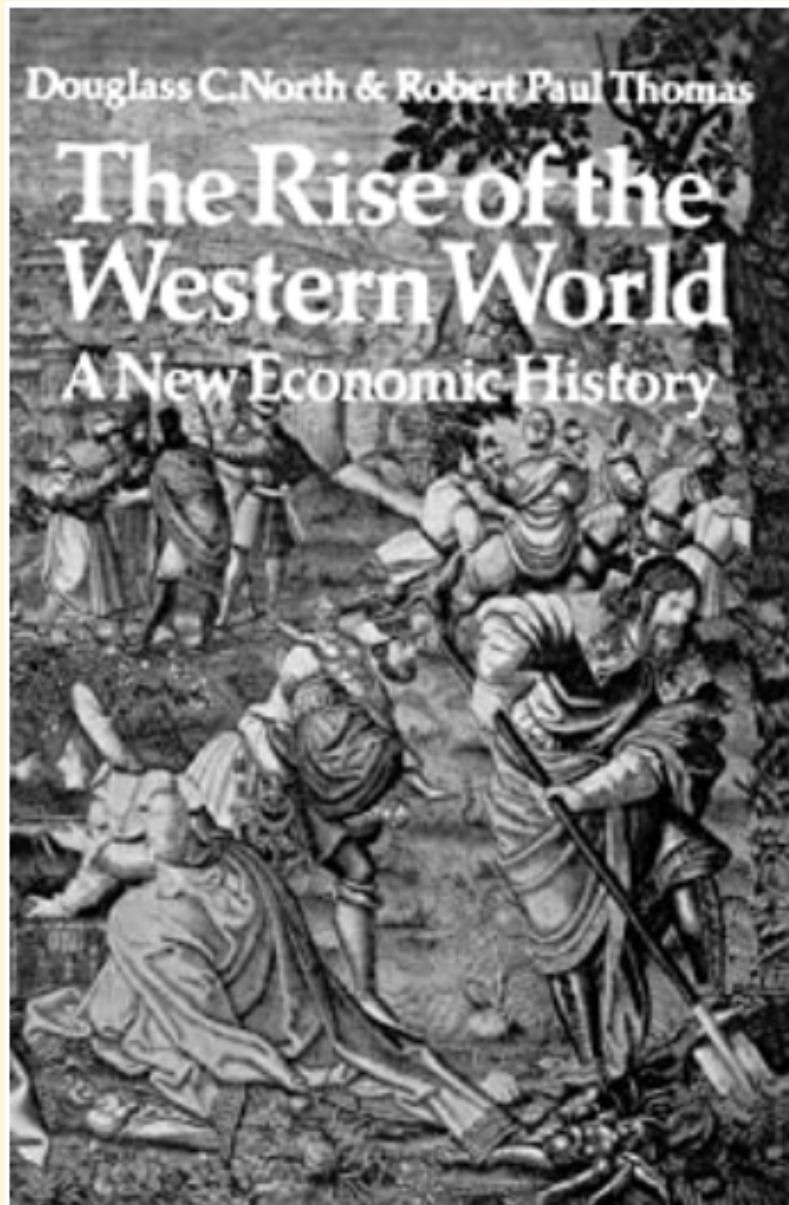
DIVERGENCE,

CHINA, EUROPE, AND THE MAKING OF
THE MODERN WORLD ECONOMY



KENNETH POMERANZ

With a new preface by the author



2025 Nobel Prize in Economics



- Joel Mokyr: “for having identified the prerequisites for sustained growth through technological progress.”
- Aghion and Howitt: “for the theory of sustained growth through creative destruction.”

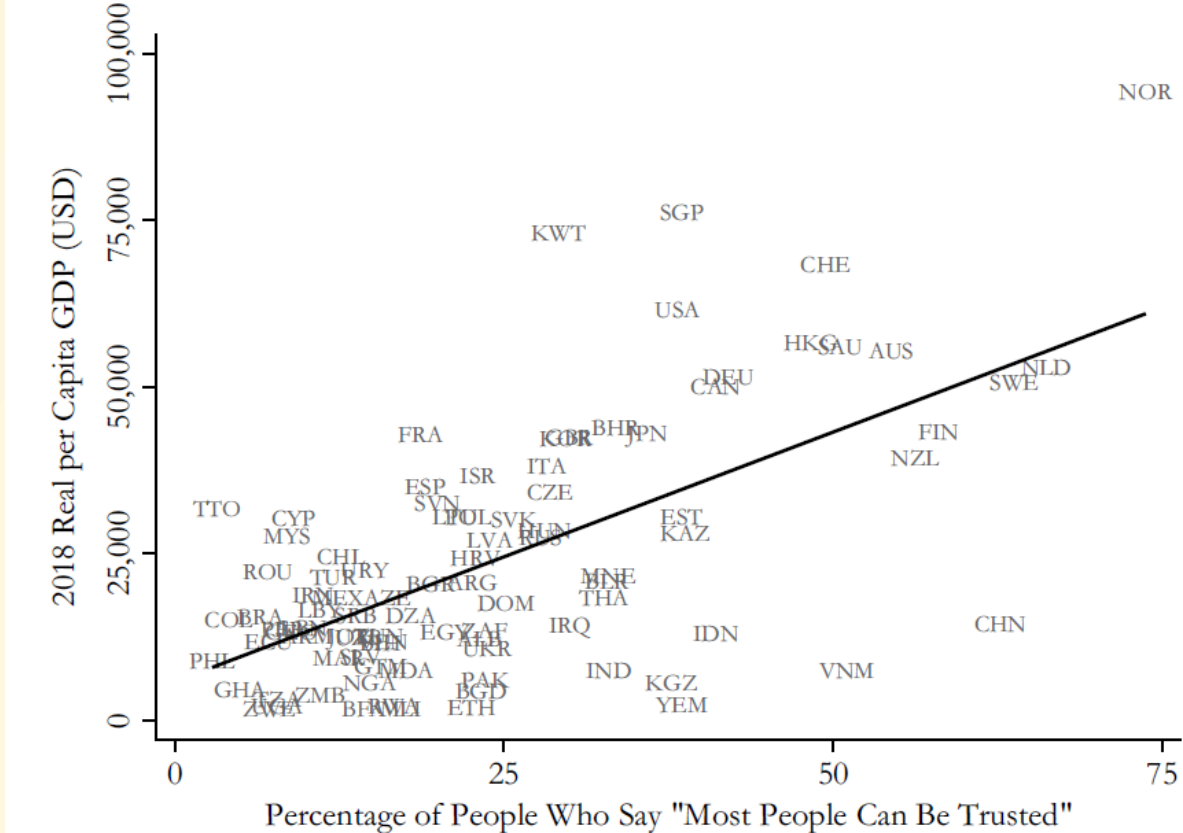
2024 Nobel Prize in Economics

"for studies of how institutions are formed and affect prosperity"





- Proximate versus Fundamental Causes
- Causal Relationships vs. Correlations
- Exogenous vs Endogenous
- Can we identify causal relationships?



KR's Explanation Categories

- Did Some Societies Win the Geography Lottery?
- Is it All Just Institutions?
- Did Culture Make Some Rich and Others Poor?
- Fewer Babies?
- Was it Just a Matter of Colonization and Exploitation?



This Week

Tuesday/Thursday: Introduction

- OG, "Mysteries of the Human Journey" (1-10)
- OG 1 "First Steps," (13-25).
- Henrich, Joseph (2017) "Chapter 1: A Puzzling Primate"
- KR 1, "Why, When, and How Did the World become rich" (1-16)

Next and every week, due the night (8am) before class

- **Two questions**

- One factual/conceptual
- One probing, to take the conversation in interesting directions.

- **Two comments**

- Agree or disagree, reframe, etc.
- Historical observation or trivia

Submit via Canvas. Due 11pm the night before class.

- **Student Led presentations**

- Groups of 4. Responsible for short slide deck, typically on additional reading.

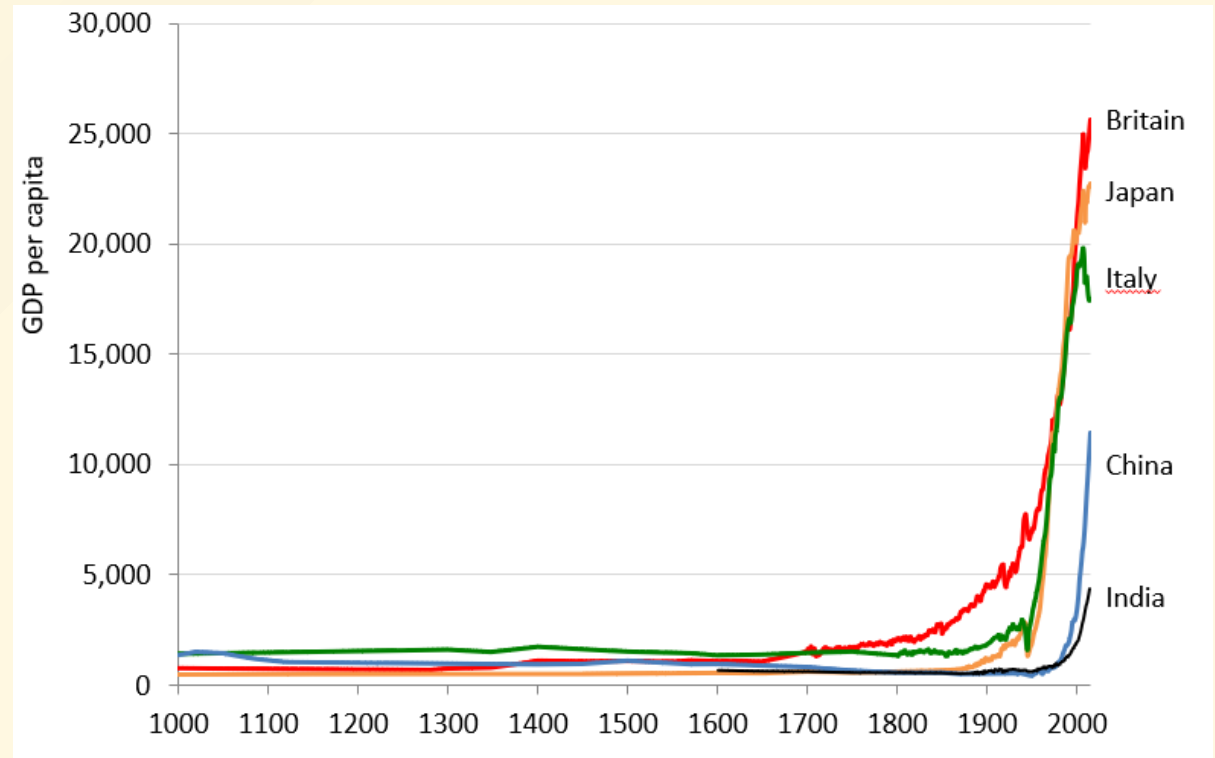
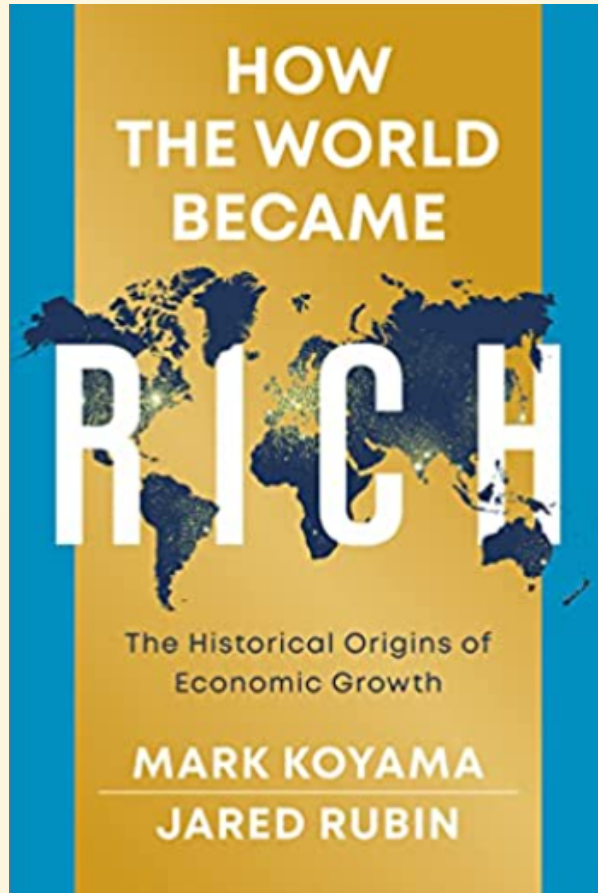
Introductions

- Your name (nickname?)
- Major/minor
- Interests in economic history.
- Anything else interesting about yourself.

Chapter 1

Why, When, and How

Did the World Become Rich?



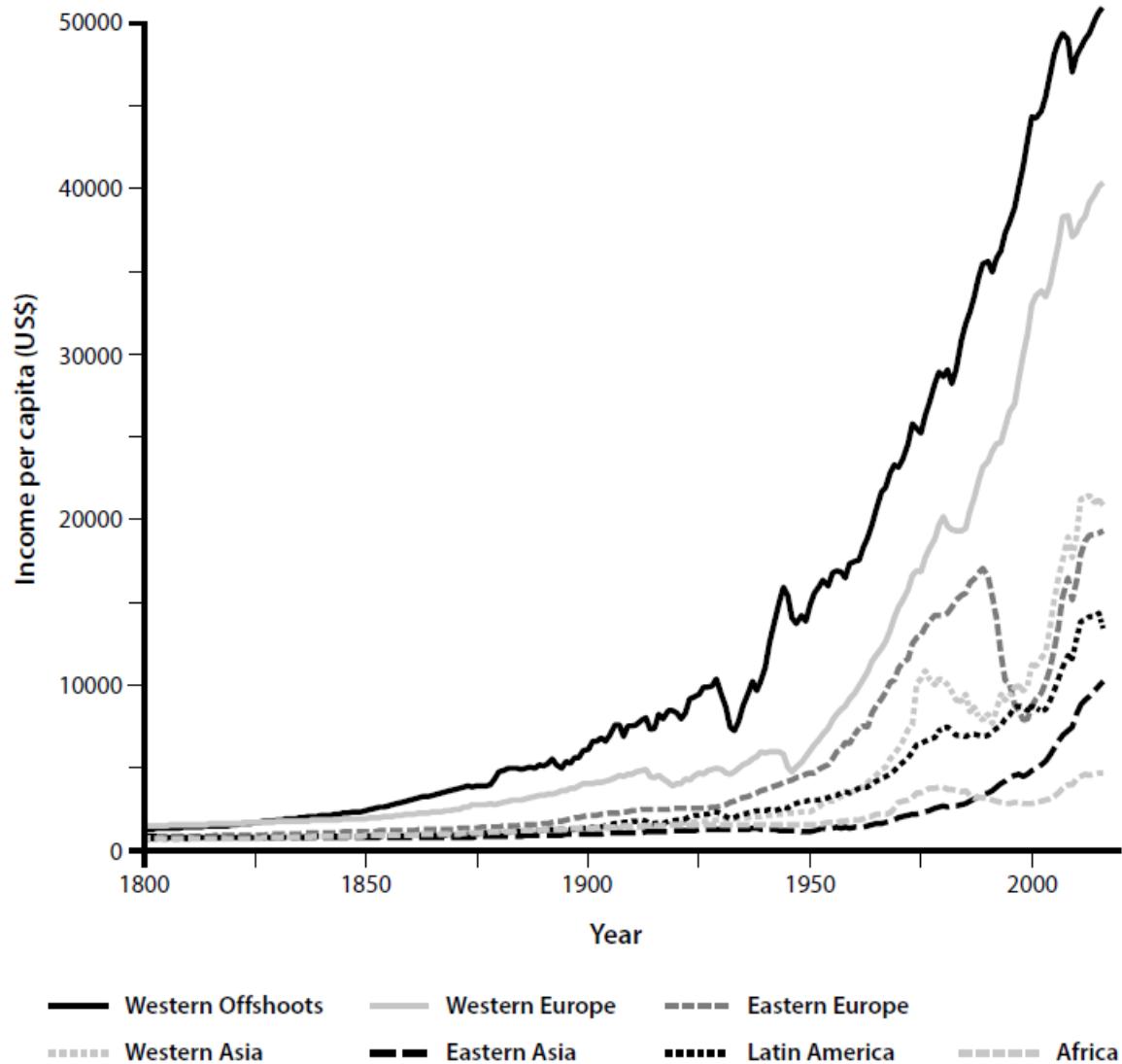


Figure 2. The Mystery of Inequality

The divergence in per capita income across world regions in the past two centuries.⁷

- What does GDP measure?
Same as income?
- Methods
 - GDP stats and deflators
 - PPP
 - Consumption baskets
 - Correlates
 - Height
 - Life Expectancy
- Are these the right measures?
 - what left out?

Growth

- Does growth bring other values?
 - What other values?
 - Tradeoffs?
- Growth vs Development
- Sustained economic growth
 - Efflorescences
 - Shrinkages

KR's list of theories

- Geography
- Institutions and Politics
- Culture
- Demographics
- Colonization and Exploitation

Non-monocausal

Contingent

Identification challenges

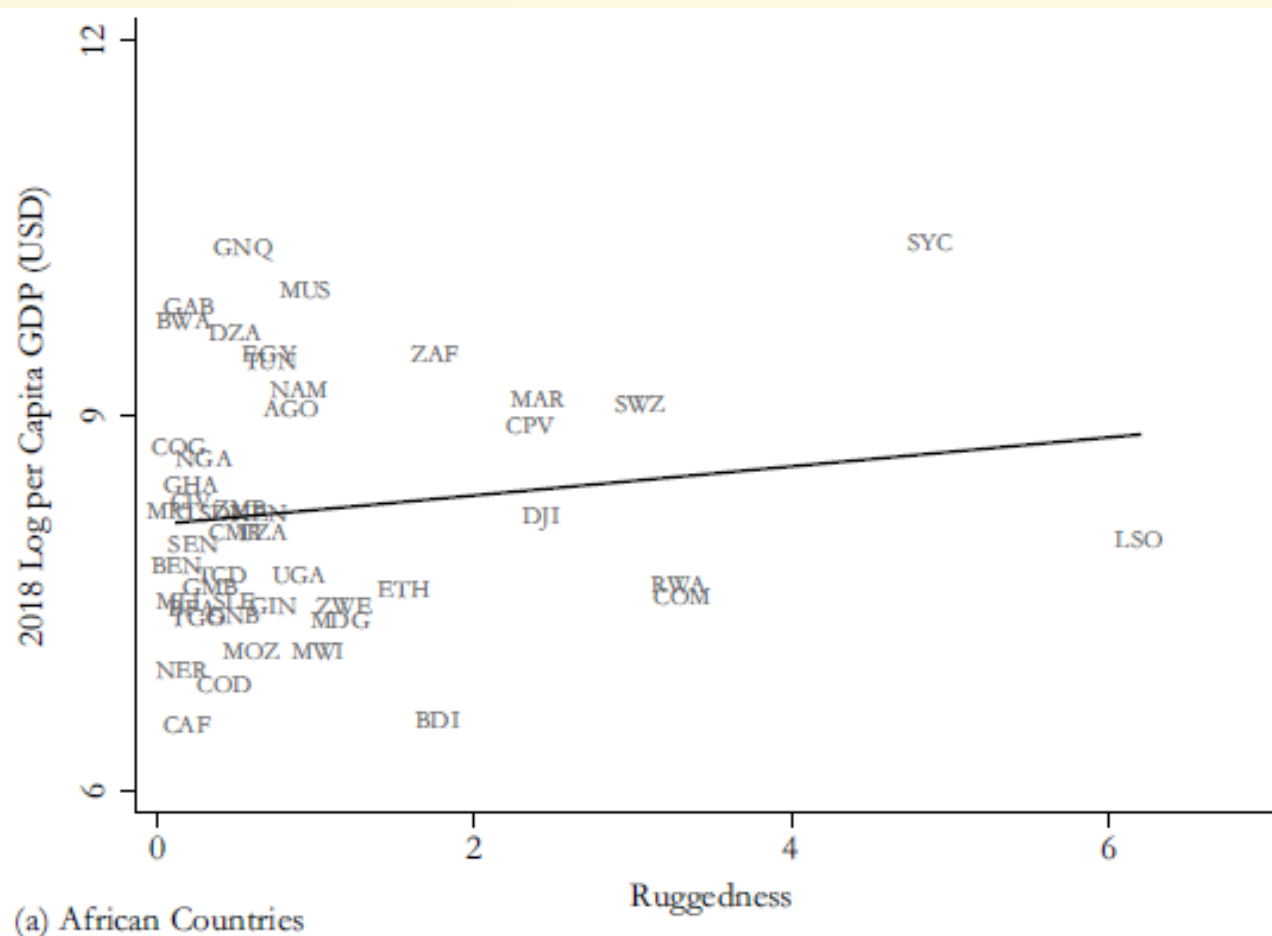
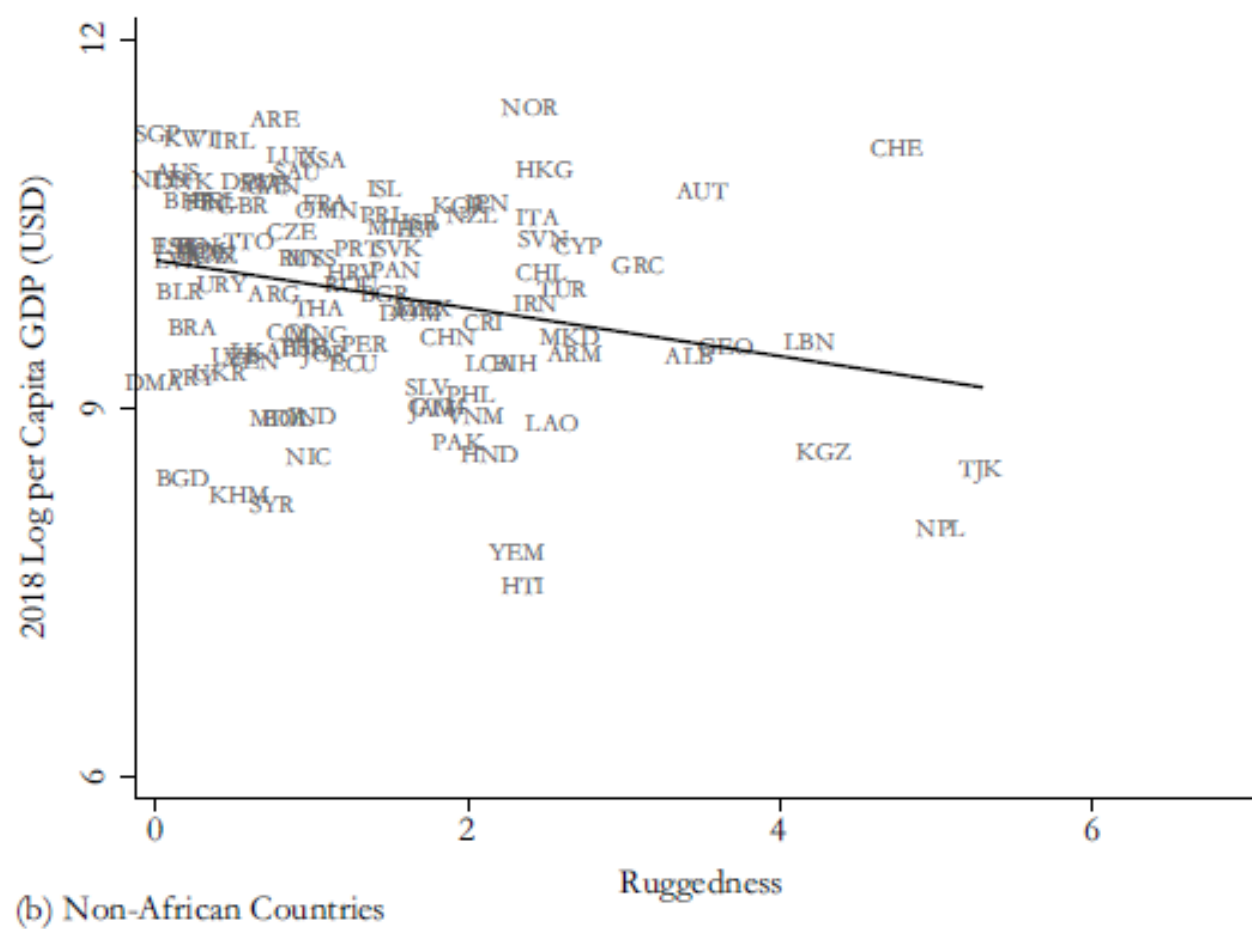


Figure 1.7 Ruggedness and income in African and non-African countries

Data sources: Nunn and Puga (2012) for ruggedness, Bolt and van Zanden (2020) for GDP per capita.

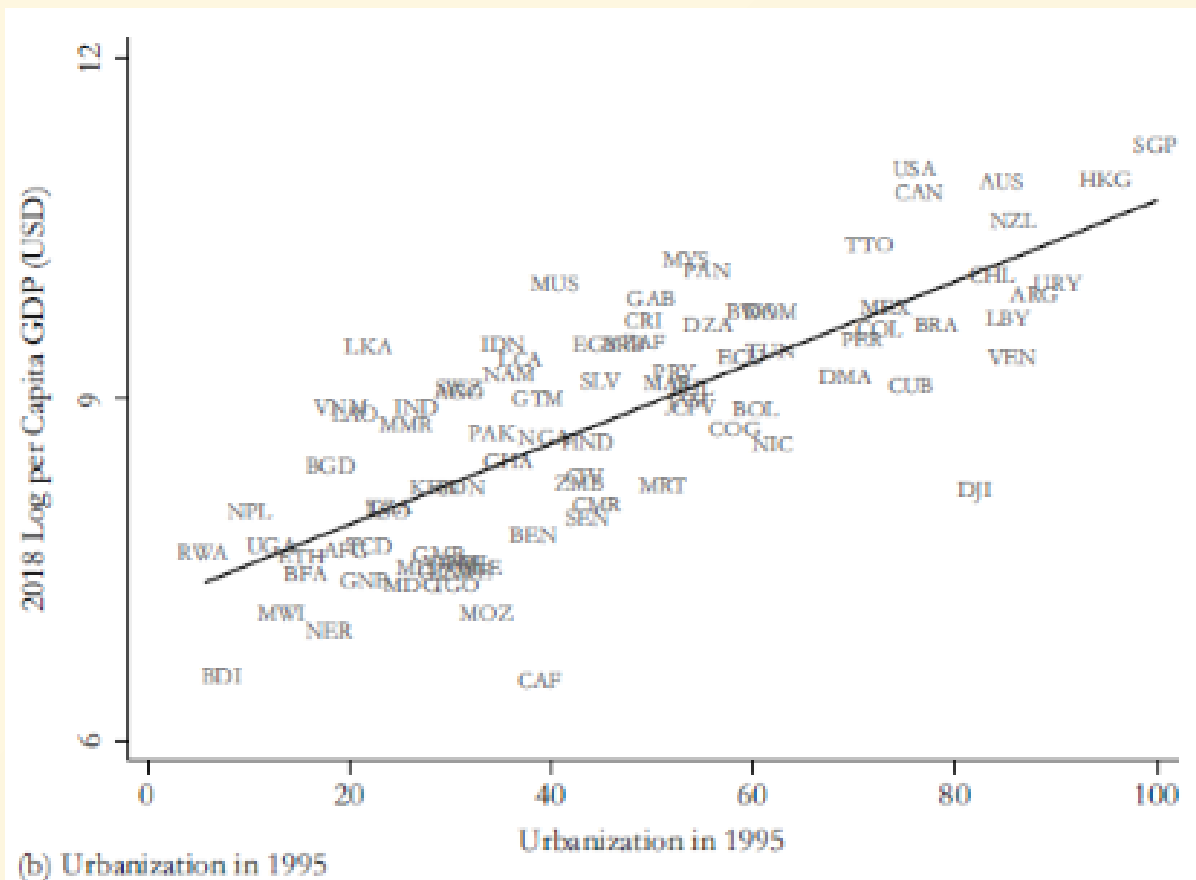
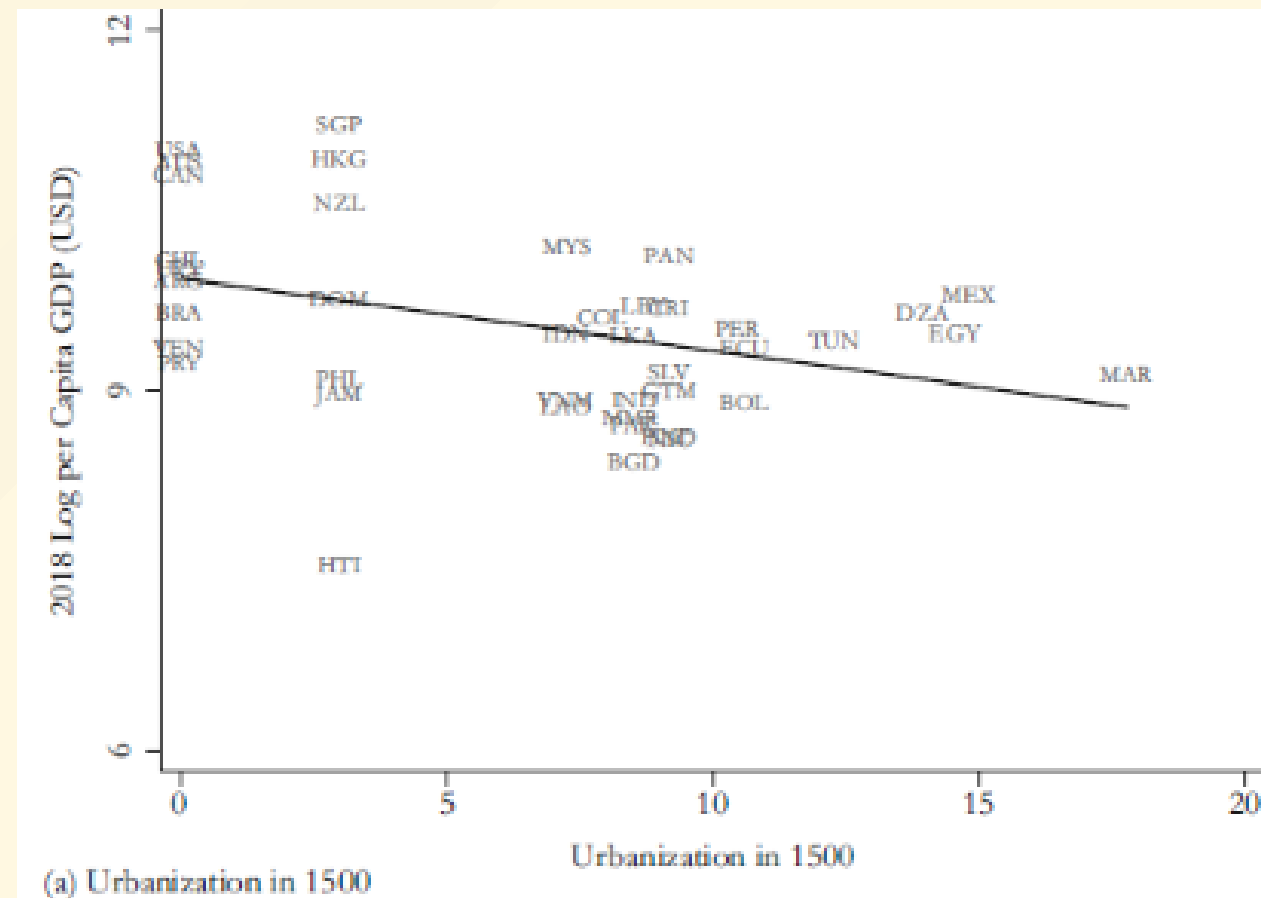


Figure 1.8 The reversal of fortunes within formerly colonized nations, 1500–1995
 Data sources: Acemoglu, Johnson, and Robinson (2002) for urbanization, Bolt and van Zanden (2020) for GDP per capita.



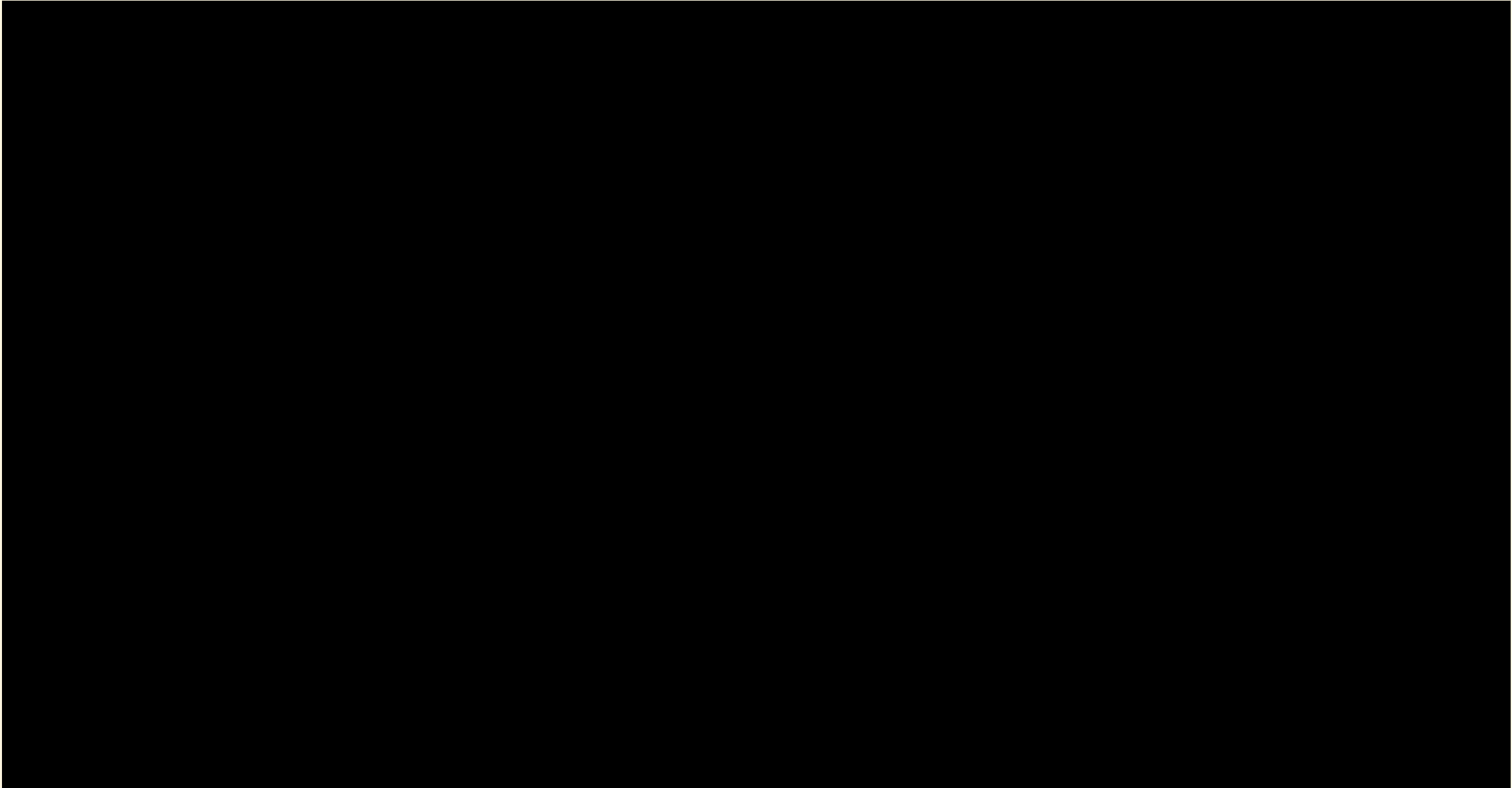
What Makes Humans Different?

A Puzzling Primate (Henrich)

- Physically weak, slow, poor climbers
- Any chimp can overpower us.
- Yet we spread to every terrestrial ecosystem on Earth
- From frozen Siberia to arid deserts to tropical rainforests

The puzzle: How did the world's most physically vulnerable primate become the most successful?

Video Title



Culture: Our Secret Superpower

Humans are a cultural species

- We learn from each other
- Knowledge accumulates across generations
- Skills improve and compound over time

Unlike other animals, humans can:

- Build on previous generations' discoveries
- Transmit complex knowledge through language
- Solve problems that no individual could figure out alone

Culture makes us smart. We are not smart because our species is innately brilliant; we are smart because we have culturally evolved vast tools and knowledge.

Language & Symbolic Thought

Language enables:

- Precise communication of complex ideas
- Storage of knowledge beyond individual memory
- Teaching of abstract concepts
- Cooperation at unprecedented scales

Without language:

- Fire, cooking, tools would not accumulate
- Each generation would start from scratch
- We could not maintain the body of knowledge needed to survive new environments

Language is uniquely human - our capacity for grammar, symbols, and abstract thought sets us apart fundamentally from all other species.

Tools, Technology & Cumulative Innovation

From Henrich: Culture-Gene Coevolution

Humans have evolved the capacity to:

- Make and use increasingly complex tools
- Learn through demonstration and imitation
- Transmit technological knowledge intergenerationally

Examples of cumulative cultural packages:

- Fire and cooking (requires knowledge transmission)
- Fishing nets and boats (requires multiple integrated skills)
- Shelters adapted to local environments
- Food preparation and preservation techniques
- Hunting strategies and weapons

Global Expansion: A Recent Phenomenon

Tens of thousands of years ago, humans migrated across the globe:

- Crossed land bridges to Australia (40,000+ years ago)
- Reached the Arctic and subarctic (20,000+ years ago)
- Adapted to every major terrestrial ecosystem
- Developed specialized technologies for each environment

The Malthusian Reality:

- For nearly 300,000 years, per capita income barely rose above subsistence
- Plagues and famines were abundant
- 25% of babies did not reach their first birthday
- Life expectancy rarely exceeded 40 years
- Population growth offset all technological gains